

Source Silence Investigation Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-40 min

Category	History	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	source-silence-investigation

Big idea: Historical knowledge depends not only on surviving sources, but also on recognizing what did not survive.

Overview

Students investigate a historical source packet by asking whose voices are missing and how silence shapes conclusions.

Student Prompt

Inspect Source Silence Investigation Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Source Silence Investigation Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Packet: official school notice, newspaper paragraph, teacher diary, but no student voices. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Source Silence Investigation Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Packet: merchant account, travel diary, law code, but no record from workers affected by the policy. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Source Silence Investigation Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Packet: merchant account, travel diary, law code, but no record from workers affected by the policy. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Historical knowledge depends not only on surviving sources, but also on recognizing what did not survive.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Source Silence Investigation Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Source Silence Investigation Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	How can we know responsibly when evidence is missing?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how historical knowledge depends not only on surviving sources, but also on recognizing what did not survive.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a packet where the missing perspective is inferable but not recoverable.
- Make students mark uncertainty rather than inventing missing testimony.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Packet: official school notice, newspaper paragraph, teacher diary, but no student voices.
- Packet: merchant account, travel diary, law code, but no record from workers affected by the policy.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Give groups a short source packet about one event.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Students list whose voices, records, or perspectives are present.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Groups infer which voices may be missing and why.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Students revise one conclusion to include uncertainty from source silence.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief how historians responsibly reason from incomplete archives.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Naming a silence is not the same as filling it with imagination.
- How does the missing voice change the strength of your conclusion?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat sources as transparent windows rather than selected traces.
- Students may confuse explaining context with excusing actions.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Uses source evidence while naming selection, silence, and perspective.
- Distinguishes historical claim, interpretation, and judgement.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: provide a checklist of possible missing voices.
- Challenge: ask students to distinguish accidental absence from deliberate exclusion.

Extension Tasks

- Students add a missing-source request: what source would most improve the account?
- Connect source silence to museums, family histories, and national archives.

Related Activities

- Broken Archive
- Memory versus Monument
- Same Event, Different Historian